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PHILIPPINE STARTUP CHALLENGE

The Next Frontier of Filipino Innovation



APPLICATION GUIDELINES



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I. RATIONALE

The Department of Information and Communications Technology (DICT), as one of the lead agencies in implementing Republic Act No. 11337, otherwise known as the "Innovative Startup Act" (ISA), is mandated to provide benefits and programs to strengthen, promote, and develop the Philippine Startup Ecosystem. To fulfill its role, the DICT is implementing startup initiatives with the goal of establishing a strong Philippine Startup Ecosystem to support and strengthen the competitive advantage of Filipino startups.

One flagship initiative under the ICT Industry Development Bureau (IIDB) is the **Philippine Startup Challenge (PSC)**. The PSC is the Department's annual startup competition among Senior High School, College Undergraduate, and Technical-Vocational Education and Training (TVET) Students. It aims to encourage and support the Filipino Youth in creating innovative and relevant ICT products and services that may potentially develop into viable business ventures as well as solve social problems.

This initiative is geared towards promoting the spirit of entrepreneurship in ICT among the youth and ensuring the continuous creation of investible ideas and startup founders that will expand the Philippine startup ecosystem. The competition is open to a broad range of technology integrations, including those enabled by Software, Internet of Things (IoT), Artificial Intelligence (AI), Web3, Blockchain, Mixed Reality, and other ICT-based products or services.





II. OBJECTIVES

To strengthen youth participation and boost the new generation of startups in the Philippines, PSC XI aims to achieve the following objectives:

1. *Promote the PSC as the flagship platform for Filipino youth-led startups nationwide through regional engagement initiatives, leveraging support from partner institutions to maximize student participation;*
2. *Enhance startup ideas through structured feedback from industry practitioners and ICT professionals during the PSC;*
3. *Provide an avenue for students to develop their entrepreneurial mindset while creating an innovative solution; and*
4. *Connect young startups to foster strategic partnerships and networks through DICT's linkages, such as the judges, industry partners, government agencies, and potential investors.*

III. QUALIFICATIONS

All teams across all regions are encouraged to have **diversified membership**. The DICT and its programs, in alignment with efforts towards equality and social inclusivity, adhere to general non-discriminatory policies extending, but not limited to, protected attributes such as age, race, gender identity, sexual orientation, disabilities, religion, and indigenous group membership, among many others.

Regional Offices (ROs) are expected to encourage participants to adhere to the team composition of **three (3) team members and one (1) mentor per application only** to ensure fairness and equity across all entries:

- The student team members should be in Senior High School, Collegiate, or TVET level;
- The student team members should be enrolled in the institution for the entire duration of the competition;





- The mentor should be employed in the same school or university as the team members; and
- The mentors are highly encouraged to participate in any DICT-led Mentors' Bootcamp or Enablement, whether by the Central Office (CO) or ROs, prior to registration (within two years from the time of the competition).

IV. ENTRY COVERAGE

Eligible startup entries may be at the **Ideation or Prototyping stage**. Startups at the Ideation stage should have a clearly defined business idea, while startups at the Prototyping stage should have developed a proof of concept or an existing prototype.

A prototype is a non-functioning model used to explore and validate an idea, while a Minimum Viable Product (MVP) is a functional version of the product used to gather customer feedback.*

The entry should leverage one or more of the following technologies:

- **Software as a Service (SaaS);**
- **Internet of Things (IoT);**
- **Artificial Intelligence (AI);**
- **Web3;**
- **Blockchain;**
- **Mixed Reality; or**
- **Other ICT-related products or services.**

* Defined herein for clarity only; startups at the MVP stage are **not** eligible under this competition.





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V. REQUIREMENTS



1. Registration

Registration shall only be made through the dedicated application links of the DICT ROs:

REGION	APPLICATION LINK
NATIONAL CAPITAL REGION	[Link here]
CORDILLERA ADMINISTRATIVE REGION	[Link here]
BANGSAMORO AUTONOMOUS REGION IN MUSLIM MINDANO	[Link here]
NEGROS ISLAND REGION	[Link here]
REGION I	[Link here]
REGION II	[Link here]
REGION III	[Link here]
REGION IV-A	[Link here]
MIMAROPA	[Link here]
REGION V	[Link here]
REGION VI	[Link here]
REGION VII	[Link here]
REGION VIII	[Link here]
REGION IX	[Link here]
REGION X	[Link here]
REGION XI	[Link here]
REGION XII	[Link here]
REGION XIII	[Link here]

* Regional Offices may opt to publish a separate post containing the same registration link to attract more participants and engage a wider audience.





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2. School Clearance

Only participants who advance to the Regional Competition (RC) shall be required to submit a school clearance, signed by the Head of the School or Institution, to the concerned RO.

Participants who advance to the National Finals shall likewise be required to submit a separate school clearance.

[Please see template - [Annex A](#)]

3. Non-Disclosure Agreement (NDA)

Only participants who advance to the RC shall be required to submit an NDA, duly signed by both the Mentor and the DICT. The NDA shall remain in effect throughout the competition and must be submitted to the concerned RO.

[Please see template - [Annex B](#)]

4. Startup Logo

The Startup Logo shall serve as the official visual identity of the submitted entry and must be submitted as a high-resolution image in PNG format.

5. Presentation Deck

Content should include the following:

- **Problem Description**
- **Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) Priority**
- **Target Market Segment**
- **Business Model**
- **Solution**
- **Features**
- **Proposed use of funds / asks from investors**
- **Progress / Traction**





In addition, the presentation deck should include an introduction of the startup founders. It should also explain the rationale behind the startup creation, as well as relevant achievements of the founders, and, if any, the startup itself.

6. Concept Note

The startup teams shall submit a concept note containing the overall details of the entry, such as:

- **Summary**
 - A brief overview of the startup idea, highlighting the problem, solution, and key value proposition.
- **Background of the Problem**
 - Description of the issue or challenge being addressed, including its context and relevance.
- **Proposed Startup Solution**
 - Explanation of the product or service and how it addresses the identified problem.
- **Objectives**
 - Clear, measurable goals the startup aims to achieve.
- **Target Market / Beneficiaries**
 - Identification of the primary users, customers, or groups who will benefit from the solution.
- **Value Proposition**
 - The unique benefits and advantages that differentiate the startup from existing alternatives.
- **Business Model**
 - Explanation of how the startup will create, deliver, and sustain value, including revenue generation.
- **Market Analysis**
 - Assessment of the target market, including size, demand, trends, and competition.
- **Operations Plan**
 - Overview of how the startup will implement and deliver its product or service.
- **Financial Requirement**
 - Estimated funding needs and how resources will be allocated to support development and operations.



VI. COMPETITION PHASES

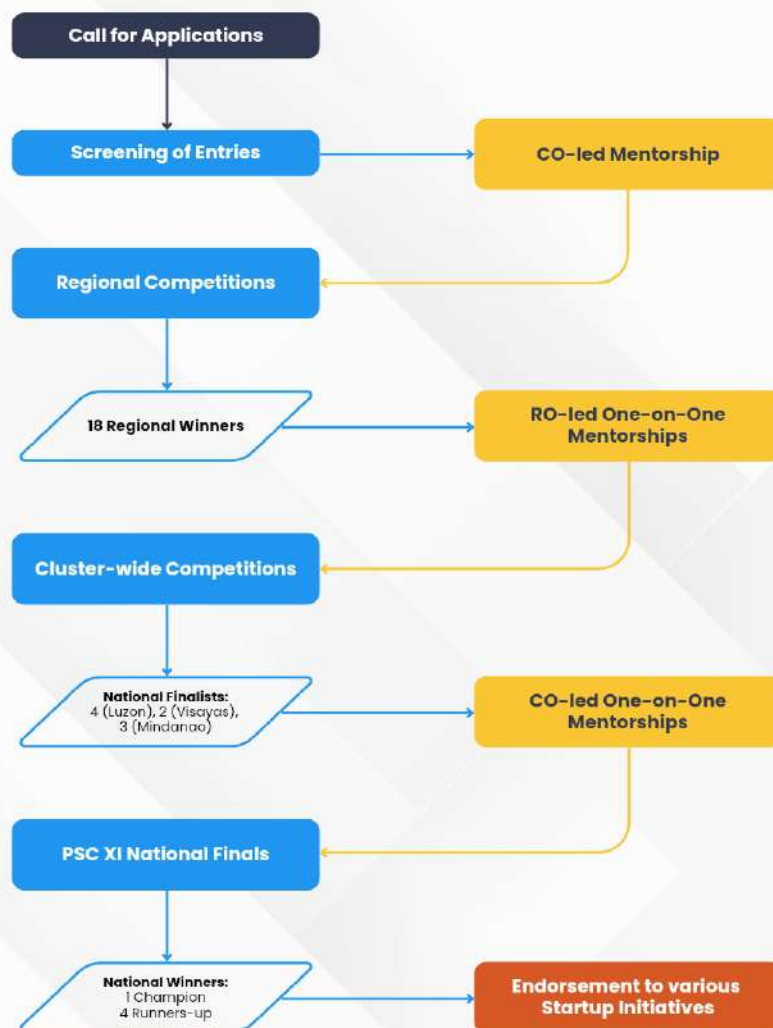


Figure 1: PSC XI Abridged Process



ICT INDUSTRY
DEVELOPMENT
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